

about money: “My mom screams at my dad to work harder cuz we have no money. Gee wiz, I wonder the fuck why?”

I remember that as a teenager, I had been aware of our money problems, but I didn’t realize until I reread this diary just how much financial anxiety I had or how much we were struggling at certain points. (We were mostly decidedly middle class.) I felt responsible for convincing my parents to see the error of their ways. I felt resentment for my sister’s insistence on buying new stuff all the time, and for my mom’s reluctance to tell her no. I felt helpless to change the situation because I was only a kid. But my parents are not bad people. Not only is their way of life super common, my dad was also contending with a disease and my mom with the consequences of that disease. They really did the best that they could with the hand we were dealt.

---

By now, both of my parents are very tired of being interrogated about their finances by their older daughter. (My dad finished his interview for the podcast in 2016 with, “Did you get what you wanted?”) My money questions have hit a collective family nerve, but I was determined to get to the bottom of what they taught me about money—lessons delivered both consciously and subconsciously.

A financial psychologist I spoke to on my podcast, Dr. Brad Klontz, says that people’s families create different money scripts—the messages we have internalized about money, like “money can solve all your problems and bring you happiness,” or “you need to treat yourself when you’re feeling sad,” can be categorized broadly as “wealthy” or “poor.” The terms *wealthy* and *poor* here have more to do with the quality of your view of money than how much money you actually have. An example of a wealthy money script would be prudently saving money in case of an emergency, and a poor money script would be the assumption that money is bad and that wealthy people are inherently evil. Parents and older family members, the first role models we really encounter, have a huge impact on our financial views. We watch the way they interact with money, and what we see shapes how we go on to spend and save. As with